

Canon PowerShot A300

Shot of power

The Canon PowerShot A300 is an entry-level 3.2 mega pixel camera, which is capable of delivering 2048 x 1536 resolutions. The camera has a 33 mm focal length equivalent to a 35 mm lens. Targeted at the price-conscious user, it does not feature optical zoom, which keeps its price under Rs 20,000. However, it does have 5.1X digital zoom—the highest in its class—that can only be used outdoors, since it leads to visible pixilation when the subject is brought too near after zooming. The camera supports an ISO setting of up to 400 that is needed when you have poor lighting, and while using a high-shutter speed of 1/2000. Also, bundled along is an external 16 MB Compact Flash memory, which can hold not more than 10 to 12 high-resolution images. Therefore, use the lower setting of 1024 x 768, or 1600 x 1200 for images that are not

aimed for printing. Memory can be upgraded, since it's not built-in.



On the performance front, the camera did not disappoint us. The test image was clear and the colours were brilliant. The A300 also managed to reproduce the colour pink of the coloured pencil, which was difficult even for some of the more expensive cameras. The details that it picked up were not crystal clear, but decent enough given its lens. It also produced impressive specular effects on the metal clock and the liquid-filled glass, which was difficult to produce for most low-end cameras. It disappointed us a little when it was tested with the RGB target, as it failed to pick up green. Instead, the green pie on the test print was very dark. Hence, preview images involving greenery before uploading them on your PC. It also returned average results when tested for zoom. The zoomed subject appeared out of focus and washed out.

The A300 weighs 175 gms, and is powered by two AA batteries. The price of Rs 19,995 makes it the most affordable option in its class, considering the features such as shutter speed range and aperture adjustments that it comes with. It sure offers better value for money to those in need of a low cost, feature-rich camera.

+ Decent features, light weight
– A bit expensive for its features
Price: Rs 19,995

Canon PowerShot A300	B-
Performance	▲▲▲▲
Features	▲▲▲▲
Ergonomics	▲▲▲▲
Value for money	▲▲▲▲

Fuji FinePix A303

Good features, bad build

FinePix A303 has an impressive list of features such as the 3.24 megapixel CCD that can be used to capture high-resolution images. The 3X optical and the 3.2X digital zoom give you breathtaking landscape photographs. Different white balance settings, such as incandescent, fluorescent and sunny, let you adjust the camera to different lighting conditions. The shutter speed range of 1/2 to 1/2000, coupled with the metering mode and the Exposure Value compensation setting, can be adjusted depending upon the lighting conditions. The Finepix A303 is bundled with a 16 MB xD-Picture card, which is insufficient, if you click a picture using maximum settings—you are likely to run out of storage space after 12 to 15 pictures, since each would amount to 1.2 MB. It weighs 200 gms without the two AA batteries, which is a bit heavy.



It managed to reproduce the pink and yellow of the coloured pencil, but they were not as vibrant as they were in the reference image. This camera, like the FinePix F402, produced images that were dark at the corners. Hence you manually need to choose a different metering mode. The specular effect was produced perfectly, with the precise amount of light reflecting on the metal and glass. The camera also scored on focusing where the tiny arm of the clock was visible, along with the keyboard text. However, the image of the wall curtain (with the fine mesh), developed untidy light and dark colour bands. This could be due to the low colour-depth supported. It also returned a darker image when tested for actual person test.

Priced at Rs 27,000, it is a bit expensive as compared to other cameras with better features. The ergonomics are also average, making it inconvenient to carry it around for a long while.

"A light-weight, simple aim-and-shoot digicam that could spell wonders for the I-don't-know-how-to-shoot amateur. Though the price is a little high. A good buy if priced between Rs 22,000 to Rs 24,000."

—Sherwin Crasto

+ Good on features
– Flimsy build quality
Price: Rs 27,000

Fuji FinePix A303	C
Performance	▲▲▲▲
Features	▲▲▲▲
Ergonomics	▲▲▲▲
Value for money	▲▲▲▲

